

Yellow Power: Building Asian Student Community Voices Against Gender-Based Violence Through Public Health Research and Art

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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The Atlanta, Georgia, spa shooting in March 2021, where six of the eight victims were Asian women, stands as a chilling reminder of how racism and misogyny intersect to justify harm to Asian women.¹ Often objectified as submissive and hypersexualized, Asian women are frequently reduced to harmful stereotypes that take away their humanity. Since the COVID-19 pandemic, this objectification has intensified with anti-Asian rhetoric scapegoating Asians for the virus, amplifying hostility and bias.²

AMPLIFYING COMMUNITY VOICES THROUGH RESEARCH

As a South Korean immigrant and public health student, I faced anti-Asian discrimination firsthand and witnessed the trauma it caused within my community. Experiencing this ongoing adversity compelled me to act. Starting in 2018,

I joined the UC Speaks Up project, which addressed sexual violence on college campuses.³ Leveraging this work, I focused my research on the Double Jeopardy Study, exploring the intersection of violence experienced by Asian students.⁴ I worked with Jianchao Lai and Jennifer Wagman to create a trauma-informed environment within a public health research framework, where victim-survivors of sexual violence could safely share their experiences.⁴ We conducted more than 50 in-depth interviews and collected more than 20 transmedia-photovoice pieces for this mixed-method study. The resilience and strength of the study participants came through as they shared their hopes for solutions to prevent violence and spare others from similar harms. I realized that my role as a public health scholar extends beyond research. I was inspired to take initiatives that supported recovery and solidarity of victim-survivors by creating beautiful community spaces.

EXPRESSING RESILIENCE AND PAIN THROUGH CREATIVE ART

My team developed transmedia-photovoice, incorporating creative writing, painting, film, and sound narratives. This approach provided participants with a broad range of expressive tools to convey their stories. Through the art, I saw pain from gendered and racialized discrimination, violence, fetishization, silence, isolation, depression, and anxiety—alongside expression of gratitude, hope, love, resilience, and strength. These layered emotions were powerfully captured in art, revealing what numbers and words alone cannot show. The complexities of violence, the subsequent harms, and the coping processes were closely tied to participants' growth and identity formation.

RESEARCH AND ART AS A CATALYST FOR DIALOGUE AND HEALING

We displayed interview quotes on yellow silk panels—our interpretation of “Yellow Power,”⁵ inspired by 1970s Asian student activism—inviting the campus community to engage with narratives usually confined to academic journals. The installation, featuring quotes from interviews and transmedia-photovoice pieces, created a beautiful space that illuminated these experiences. The weeklong exhibition, culminating in a panel discussion, reached students and community members from UCLA and other campuses across Los Angeles, California, highlighting the power of creatively expressed lived experiences. Through this exhibition, we revealed the

pervasive and often covert forms of violence against Asian communities. The open dialogue on stigmatized topics like sexual violence and racism was made possible by the art exhibition, which fostered respectful and empathetic discussion. The exhibit grounded participants in shared experiences and understanding as the community connected through the art, offering insights that will shape our future work in violence prevention and intervention.

CONCLUSION

Art can feel intimidating in public health where there is no clear right or wrong answer and no *P* value to indicate significance. When I voiced these concerns, Lauren, an artist and a professor at UCLA Design Media Arts, simply said, "Have fun with it. Experiment with it and see where it takes you." That encouragement helped me embrace uncertainty and explore creatively with an open mind. As I continue to uplift often-silenced voices through research and art, I have found my own community of support—a network of shared resilience and hope. Together, we are forging a path toward healing and understanding, showing that public health can be a space not only for prevention but also for connection, reconciliation, and growth. *AJPH*

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CONFLICTS OF INTEREST

The author has no conflicts of interest to report.

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